

[About EDS](#)[About us](#)[Our board](#)[What we do](#)[Policy](#)[Litigation](#)[Events](#)[Areas of work](#)[Publications](#)[Bookstore](#)[Documents](#)[Get involved](#)[Support EDS](#)[Donate](#)[Young lawyer
fund](#)[Students](#)**Support
EDS****Environmental
Defence
Society**

[< All media statements](#)

Marine spatial planning is a game-changer

02 December 2024

The Environmental Defence Society today released a Working Paper on marine spatial planning (MSP) setting out how the approach could be more widely applied in Aotearoa New Zealand. The report, titled *Restoring the Sea: The role of marine spatial planning*, is co-authored by Raewyn Peart, Deidre-Koolen-Bourke and Salif Sidibe.

“Marine spatial planning is commonplace overseas with over 120 countries and territories now having MSP in place. However, we have been slow to adopt the approach in this country,” said EDS Policy Director Raewyn Peart.

“Our research identified substantial benefits that MSP could provide for Aotearoa New Zealand. They include better integrating oceans management at place, restoring healthy marine ecosystems, supporting the development of a stronger blue economy, and empowering hapū, whānau and local communities to better manage their local marine areas.

“We interviewed a range of people for the project, including those who had been involved in the Sea Change Tai Timu Tai Pari MSP initiative in the Hauraki Gulf.

Eight years on from that process, which is still in its implementation phase, they saw

enduring benefits. However, it is clear that future MSP processes need to have a statutory foundation to ensure faster delivery of key outcomes.

"We also investigated a range of other marine initiatives around the country, including in Fiordland, Kaikōura, Bay of Plenty, Marlborough Sounds, Northland and Otago. These case studies highlighted the potential of local initiatives, and the strong desire of local communities to become actively involved to improve the state of their marine environments.

"We also reviewed international MSP best practice and identified a growing focus on addressing climate change impacts, as well as supporting marine restoration, recognising the considerable amount of marine degradation which has already occurred.

"Our report proposes that a statutory 'National MSP Framework' be developed to support MSP processes around the country. It also calls for the establishment of a 'Marine Restoration Fund' to financially support the development and implementation of regional and local plans.

"Sources of funding could include coastal occupation charges, charges on public boat ramps and fisheries permits, levies on quota owners, port tariffs, charges on Department of Conservation marine concessions and targeted rates.

"Many of our coastal areas are under enormous pressure, and MSP provides a way to better manage conflicts while at the same time supporting economic opportunities and a healthier marine environment," concluded Ms Peart.

For more: Raewyn Peart 021613379 raewyn@eds.org.nz

A copy of the Working Paper can be accessed [here](#).

+64 9 302 2972

manager@eds.org.nz



Donate to EDS

Become a Supporter

Newsletter signup

© Copyright 2026 Environmental Defence Society • T&Cs